

GAMING



Mastercard denies pressuring game platforms, Valve tells a different story

The outcry after a recent marketplace crackdown on games with adult content, seemingly due to pressure from payment processors, prompted Mastercard to release [a brief statement](#) Friday pushing back against recent headlines.

“Mastercard has not evaluated any game or required restrictions of any activity on game creator sites and platforms, contrary to media reports and allegations,” the company said, adding, “At the same time, we require merchants to have appropriate controls to ensure Mastercard cards cannot be used for unlawful purchases, including illegal adult content.”

IMAGE CREDITS:

ROBERTO MACHADO NOA / GETTY IMAGES

This follows [an open letter](#) by the advocacy group Collective Shout addressed to executives at Paypal, Mastercard, Visa, and other companies, criticizing them for allowing the sale of “No Mercy” and other games that depict rape, incest, and child sexual abuse.

In the following weeks, Steam announced that it would ban games that violate the rules of its “payment processors and related card networks and banks.” Then [Itch.io](#) said it was [removing games with adult content](#) from its browse and search pages while conducting a broader audit.

While Mastercard’s statement seems to undermine the narrative that payment and card companies were the ones pressuring the game marketplaces,

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Steam owner Valve responded with a statement of its own, [provided to PC Gamer](#) and other gaming sites.

According to Valve, “Mastercard did not communicate with Valve directly, despite our request to do so. Mastercard communicated with payment processors and their acquiring banks. Payment processors communicated this with Valve, and we replied by outlining Steam’s policy since 2018 of attempting to distribute games that are legal for distribution.”

Valve said its response was “rejected” by the payment processors, who noted the “risk to the Mastercard brand” and pointed to a Mastercard rule against “illegal or brand-damaging transactions.”



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Meanwhile, [Itch.io](#) said that it’s now [re-indexing free games with adult content](#) while negotiating with payment processors including Stripe, which for its part said it’s “unable to support sexually explicit content” due to “banking partners.”

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Anthony Ha is TechCrunch’s weekend editor. Previously, he worked as a tech reporter at Adweek, a senior editor at...

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Google bets on STAN, an Indian social gaming platform

Jagmeet Singh — 10:05 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

Google has backed [STAN](#), an Indian social gaming platform that connects gamers with creators, communities, and publishers.

Google's investment comes as part of an \$8.5 million equity funding round, which also saw investment from Japanese gaming giants Bandai Namco Entertainment, Square Enix, and Reazon Holdings. Aptos Labs and King River Capital, as well as existing backers General Catalyst and GFR Fund, also participated. Google joined the round via its [AI Futures Fund](#), which [launched](#) in May to support startups building with its AI tools.

STAN, headquartered in Singapore, is trying to position itself as a gaming community platform to rival Discord, but its approach to the market is quite different. STAN lets users earn in-app currency called "Gems" by winning games like Krafton's Battlegrounds Mobile India, Garena's Free Fire Max, Minecraft, Call of Duty, or casual titles like Ludo and Snakes & Ladders.

The app also lets creators set up chat rooms called Clubs, which are channels tailored for each game on the platform. While anyone can join these Clubs, they need to pay a social currency to access the

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“gaming experiences” that creators offer. The startup takes a commission from these transactions.

The primary attraction seems to be the in-app currency, however, as it can be redeemed for vouchers on various e-commerce platforms like Amazon, PhonePe, and Flipkart. Users can also earn currency via referrals, a spin-to-win wheel, and daily rewards.

It appears STAN’s monetization model is what sets it apart: Users can earn rewards through interactions, unlike on Discord, where chatting or participating in communities doesn’t earn users much, apart from clout.

Nonetheless, STAN wants to shadow Discord. The company claims it has already garnered over 25 million downloads on the Play Store and App Store altogether, and it has around 5.5 million monthly active users.



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IMAGE CREDITS:STAN

“STAN is the hangout place for gamers. It’s a place where gamers come and make friends, play with each other, talk to each other, sort of a fusion of social and gaming,” said Parth Chadha, co-founder and CEO of STAN, in an interview.

Chadha credits the platform’s features for its traction so far. Initially, creators had to contact the company’s team to start streaming, but last year, the startup opened the platform to user-generated content, allowing anyone to go live. That shift helped drive both downloads and engagement, the CEO said.

STAN also works with game publishers, studios, and developers, including Krafton, Garena, and Roblox, who pay the startup to connect them with gamers and creators on the platform.

Chadha told TechCrunch that in the past two quarters, nearly 100 game publishers, studios, and developers have joined the platform, and it is bringing more than 20 on board each month.

“That is turning into a very interesting business stream as we speak,” he said.

Looking ahead, STAN plans to leverage Google’s backing to use AI to improve moderation.

Currently 70% to 80% of moderation on STAN is already handled by AI, Chadha said. A human moderation team manages the rest, but the startup plans to reduce that further by using AI.

Additionally, STAN aims to bring AI-powered toolkits for creators, including the ability to produce avatars and memes, as well as tools for quick replies and filtering out chats.

“There are a lot of interesting plug-and-play models, which we and the Google team are working together to leverage and scale the business,” he stated.

STAN isn’t the first Indian startup to be backed by Google’s AI Futures Fund. That distinction goes to [Toonsutra](#), a startup using AI to power an [immersive comic-reading experience](#).

Google confirmed to TechCrunch that it has invested over \$5.5 billion in India to date, including in startups Toonsutra, STAN, Pixxel, and Adda247.

Although STAN’s app is currently geo-restricted to India, the platform still sees 5% to 6% of its engagement coming from users abroad, who often access it using Indian phone numbers and accounts. Over the next year, the startup plans to expand internationally, starting with the Indian subcontinent, and will later target Southeast Asia and Latin America.

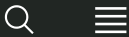
The startup was profitable for a few months, the CEO said, but decided to spend some money to scale. Now it aims to achieve profitability in 2027, he added.

Currently, the startup employs about 40 people; less than 30 of them work in product engineering.

With this raise, STAN’s total equity funding now stands at around \$15 million.



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Nintendo raising original Switch console prices due to ‘market conditions’

Nintendo is raising the prices of its original Nintendo Switch game consoles, the [company announced on Friday](#). The price increases, which are taking effect on August 5, are due to “market conditions,” Nintendo says.

The company’s reference to “market conditions” likely hints at [President Donald Trump’s tariffs](#).

The affected products include the Nintendo Switch — OLED Model, Nintendo Switch, Nintendo Switch Lite, and select Nintendo Switch accessories. Other Nintendo products, including certain Nintendo Switch 2 accessories, select amiibo, and the Nintendo Sound Clock: Alarmo, will also see price increases.

It’s not yet clear what the new prices will be. Currently, the original Nintendo Switch retails for \$299.99, while the OLED model costs \$349.99.

IMAGE CREDITS: DARRELL ETHERINGTON

Nintendo said it isn’t ruling out a future price hike for the [Nintendo Switch 2](#), which retails for \$450.

“Pricing for the Nintendo Switch 2 system, physical and digital Nintendo Switch and Nintendo Switch 2 games, as well as Nintendo Switch Online memberships, will remain unchanged at this time,” Nintendo wrote in its announcement post.

“However, please note that price adjustments may be necessary in the future.”

Earlier on Friday, Nintendo reported its [fiscal first-quarter earnings](#) and shared that sales of the Switch 2 console have reached 5.82 million units since its release on June 5.

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Nintendo transferred most of its production from China to Vietnam in the past to [avoid tariffs](#). However, Trump this week announced changes to [reciprocal tariffs](#), which extend to Vietnam.



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Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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Google proposes to open Play Store to more real-money games in India

Jagmeet Singh — 1:57 PM PDT · July 30, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Google has proposed sweeping changes to its Play Store and advertising policies in India, aiming to

allow more real-money gaming apps onto its platforms in a bid to settle an ongoing antitrust case with a local online gaming platform WinZO.

On Wednesday, India's competition watchdog issued a [public notice](#) (PDF) inviting comments on a "commitment proposal" from Google, offering to expand access to its Play Store and advertising policy for more real-money gaming apps in the South Asian market.

Google proposed to replace its current pilot program by allowing the distribution of all real-money games in the country — which are "self-declared by developers as permissible online real-money games as per applicable laws/jurisprudence" — on Google Play.

However, the developers are also required to submit proof that an authoritative third-party body has declared the app to be a "game of skill," the company proposed.

In September 2022, Google [launched a pilot program](#) to allow daily fantasy sports and rummy games on its Play Store in India. The move came after a 2021 ruling by India's Supreme Court that categorized fantasy sports as "games of skill" rather than gambling — and therefore "legal."

Shortly after the pilot announced, online gaming platform WinZO [filed a complaint](#) with the Delhi High Court, calling the program discriminatory for excluding other real-money games. The Competition Commission of India (CCI) took up the case and, in November last year, [ordered a formal probe](#) into Google's policies for real-money gaming apps.

In January last year, Google announced it would expand support for real-money gaming apps on the Play Store in India, Brazil, and Mexico. However, the

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company [paused](#) that rollout in June 2024 and stated it would continue to allow apps already included in the 2022 India pilot to remain on the platform.



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Alongside offering to expand its Play Store for all real-money games self-declared by developers, Google proposed to update its Developer Program Policies to reflect the update. The company also stated that it would finalize an “appropriate business model” for real-money game developers.

Similarly, Google has proposed to allow “games of skill” to be advertised in India where the app maker provides proof by a third party that it is a game of skill and not gambling.

The recognized third parties in this case could even be industry associations such as the All India Gaming Federation, E-Gaming Federation, or the Federation of Indian Fantasy Sports.

Google said it would begin allowing compliant real-money games on its Play Store in India within 120 days of the CCI's approval, while related ad policy changes would take effect within 150 days of the regulator's order.

“We're pleased the CCI is market testing our proposed framework for real-money games (RMGs) in India,” a Google spokesperson said in a statement emailed to TechCrunch. “This development reflects our constructive discussions with the CCI and the Indian developer community along with our commitment to building a more open and safe ecosystem for RMG apps across Google Play and Google Ads.”

Notably, the proposal, if it is accepted by the CCI after public feedback, would benefit Google, which stands to earn a share of revenue from a broader range of real-money gaming apps and their ads on its platforms.

Real-money gaming dominates India's online gaming market, accounting for nearly 86% of total industry revenue — ₹274.38 billion (\$3 billion) in 2024 — per a [joint report](#) by WinZO and the Interactive Entertainment and Innovation Council (IEIC) released earlier this year. However, its share is expected to decline slightly to 80% by 2029, as non-real-money games grow in popularity and the overall market expands to ₹785.51 billion (\$8.9 billion).

Google's latest proposal could also offer a boost to developers currently distributing their apps outside the Play Store — including via APK files on their own websites. However, the CCI's investigation is still ongoing, and the regulator has yet to determine whether Google engaged in discriminatory practices in this space.

The probe adds to a growing list of antitrust challenges for Google in India, where the U.S.-headquartered tech giant [has already been fined](#) for [allegedly abusing its dominance](#) through Android and the Play Store. The company recently [approached the Supreme Court](#) to appeal one of these rulings and contest the CCI's findings. The case is expected to be listed for hearing next month.

“We look forward to continuing to work with the CCI and the wider RMG ecosystem, and are confident our proposed framework will empower Indian developers, grow the digital economy, and prioritize user safety,” Google’s spokesperson said.

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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